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“It is a blot on my character. I will resign and consider myself guilty until I am cleared by the courts and proven innocent.”

OMAR ABDULLAH, *Chief Minister*

Abdullah, son of Dr Farooq Abdullah,” he told the House. “With a heavy heart, I must say Omar Abdullah has lost the moral authority to rule the state. He must resign.”

Perhaps the PDP legislators had not expected the chief minister to react the way he did. But the party's desperation to see Omar's back could not be missed. As the chief minister was crafting his resignation letter at his Gupkar Road residence, a few hundred metres away, Baig fired another salvo from his party president

Mehbooba's official residence disclosing that Omar's father Farooq Abdullah's name too figured in the list at number 38. Political observers say it was a pre-emptive move to block the senior Abdullah's chances of replacing his son if Omar's resignation was accepted by the governor. But by then, the NC crisis managers had tweaked the resignation offer into an equivocal appeal to the governor. “I would be grateful if you could inquire into the allegations against me in a time-bound manner and if you are satisfied

that there is any basis in these allegations, please accept my resignation immediately,” Omar's letter said. The letter was a total turnaround from what the chief minister had said on the floor of the House. Experts say this appeal constitutes a “bizarre” expectation from the constitutional head of the state who has “no powers to investigate the allegations and give a verdict in a politically sensitive case pending in many courts”. Omar's letter to the governor left him with no choice but to ask the chief minister to continue in office till a final decision is taken. Technically, Omar never actually resigned. The entire drama triggered by the PDP marked a new nadir in the state's politics.

Since the party lost power to the NC, the PDP has not missed an opportunity to appropriate public anger against Omar's Government over incidents like the double rape and murder in Shopian, and then the killings in Baramulla and Bomai. The party has consistently invested itself in trying to project the NC as anti-people, now also by conjoining the ruling party with the issue of morality. The PDP has not hesitated to take its audacious theatrics inside the legislative House. “The PDP has already been able to unnerve the NC rank and file by resurrecting the highly emotive sexploitation issue. But it could once again destabilise the entire state,” says a political analyst, adding, “That may be too high a cost for political bickering.” By using issues like the sex scandal which touches a raw nerve in already restive Kashmir, the PDP seems to have opened a Pandora's box. Although the case was long put in cold storage, it's a widely held belief that the scandal is just the tip of the iceberg. The rumour list of those allegedly involved in the sex scandal reads like a who's who of the state.

As a populist strategy, tapping into the separatist space has become the lifeline of a fast changing PDP. The party has been working to appropriate every popular sentiment prevalent in J&K. In an attempt to further consolidate that political space, the neo-separatist pro-India party had